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THEOLOGICAL DATA AND METHOD

JOHN COBB*

I

IN RECENT years men have realized as never before that thought and the statement arising from it, even when consciously directed toward the search for truth, is conditioned by a multiplicity of factors of which loyalty to truth is only one. The many factors influencing thought may be grouped together in a variety of ways for fruitful study. For the purposes of this essay in theological method they are considered under a three-part division as particularizing factors, relativizing factors, and universalizing factors.

By "particularizing factors" is to be understood the subject matter of any particular thought process, the problem with which it is approached, the particular facts and experiences which afford data for the inquiry, and the starting point which is selected among these data. For statement, the question of audience is an additional particularizing factor. Thought is about something, and that thought which seeks truth must be stimulated by some problem and must begin with something given in the realm of what is at least conceived as real. The choice of subject matter and data necessarily determines to a great extent the character of the conclusions.

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By "relativizing factors" is to be understood all the influences upon thought on any particular subject which are relative to particular men living under particular circumstances. These include all the peculiarities of individual temperament and class interest; all the variations of training, knowledge, and intellectual ability; all the socially conditioned interpretations, evaluations, and superstitions to which men are subject. Thought upon the subject of the proper organization of society necessarily differs greatly in thirteenth-century France and in twentieth-century America and differs within both environments also from individual to individual.

By "universalizing factors" is meant those determinants of thought which are constant for all thought in all ages to the extent that thought is self-conscious. The chief, and perhaps only, such factor is consistency of an idea within itself and with other beliefs. In proportion as it achieves self-consciousness, the human mind cannot at one time both affirm and deny a single idea precisely understood. In proportion as the interrelations of ideas become apparent, the necessity of consistency extends to them and ultimately, in principle if seldom in fact, implies that all beliefs entertained by a single mind must be rendered consistent with one another. The movement of thought originating in a particular set of data is influenced, then, by all the relativizing factors noted but is determined also by the demands of consistency within itself and ultimately with other beliefs. Consistency with other beliefs may, of

course, involve relativizing factors. Indeed some of these factors operate in large part by their demand that the newly developing thought harmonize with beliefs they have instilled. But it involves a qualifiedly universalizing factor as well, in that consistency is demanded also with irreducible facts which seem to be little influenced by differences of time, place, and personality. The body of known fact is constantly growing, and, even though it may apparently suffer a certain amount of change because of the inescapable element of human fallibility, consistency with all known facts must be regarded as a universalizing rather than a relativizing factor.

The boundaries between these three sets of factors are not as sharp as this analysis might suggest. The influence of relativizing factors upon both particularizing and universalizing ones is complex, and they are themselves largely determined by the others. There is no starting point in one set of factors upon which the others have not already acted. No factor is given in isolation in reality, and each must be abstractly isolated therefrom. Yet generalization and abstraction are the *sine qua non* of thought, and, when clearly recognized as such, they are not vicious.

II

Theological statement is no exception to the foregoing analysis of thought and its statement. It has distinctive problems, subject matter, data, and starting points, which are treated in accordance with the demands of logic and dealt with in the context of a given world view. But, more than any other field of thought, theology is confused as to its subject and data and uncertain as to its proper relation to world views and logical demands.

Before questions of subject matter,

data, and starting point can be raised, the purpose of theology must be determined. Theology is understood here as an intellectual discipline to be distinguished from faith, which is a personal response to God. The purpose of theology thus understood, even if it should be to force the assent of the mind by rational proof, could not be to arouse faith. Apart from this, a variety of purposes are possible and continue to motivate theologians today as in the past.

Differences of purpose may well direct theologians to different subject matters, cause them to find their data in diverse places and to select varying starting points from among them. The purpose of theology may be the discovery of religious truth or it may be the statement or communication of such truth. Statement may be for the purpose of clarification only or also for persuasion or proof. This depends largely upon the audience to which the statement is directed. Theology as discovery is not directed toward any audience other than self. Theology as statement is primarily for an audience, and the problem and the composition of the audience are interdeterminate.

If the audience is composed of believers, clarification is the purpose of theology. Clarification, in turn, may be for purposes of dogmatic instruction only or for exhortation and application as well, and it may extend to the effort to decide matters at issue among believers. The subject matter of such an endeavor is co-extensive with the subjects about which definite beliefs are held in the religious community, and the data consist of whatever are recognized therein as authoritative for belief. For the Roman Catholic theologian, the data for such an undertaking are the existing formulations of belief adopted by the church. For the biblical theologian, the data are

beliefs expressed in the Bible, whether these are found by the juxtaposition of proof texts, by the scholarly exegesis of key books and passages, or by an interpretation of the spirit and meaning of the whole. For the confessional theologian, the data are the beliefs of a particular community expressed in their worship and common life.

If the audience is composed of nonbelievers, the purpose may still be clarification only, but more commonly it includes persuasion or proof. The subject matter may be all the beliefs held by the theologian or any part of them. Where proof is sought, data must be found in what is given also to the nonbeliever, and the argument must proceed along lines conceived as logically inescapable. Actually, the possibility of proof in this strict sense is rarely affirmed today. If persuasion is his aim, the theologian seeks data and starting point in the experience of the nonbeliever, either in a felt need, in a recognized situation, or in already existing beliefs. His effort may be to demonstrate the high value of his faith in terms of its ability to satisfy social or psychological needs or to illuminate the historical or personal situation, or it may be to show the plausibility of his faith in terms of existing patterns of belief and expectation.

Finally, the audience to which the theologian addresses himself may be composed of those who doubt and are religiously bewildered. Doubt and bewilderment presuppose an essentially positive concern. Normally they result from the impact upon an established faith of novel experiences, ideas, and beliefs not clearly harmonious with it. These experiences, ideas, and beliefs constitute obstacles to faith which, if not removed, weaken and ultimately undermine that

faith. The source of these obstacles may be sin, in which case theology in itself is of little help. The source may, however, lie in thought and ideas, in which case only theology can help. The theologian who addresses himself to such a doubter need not undertake to prove doctrines of faith or even to show their value. The doubter has been a believer and knows something of the value of faith. His faith rests ultimately not on rational proof but on experience. The theologian's task is to remove the obstacles to belief. Subject, data, starting point, and method may vary as the theologian directs himself to the myriad problems which present themselves. The theologian may prefer, however, to seek a systematic statement of the faith, such that within it all intellectual obstacles to belief can be resolved for those who are inclined by prior experience to such belief. Such a statement would have value not only for all honest doubters but also for all believers who may be led to doubt by future experiences and the impact of new ideas.

Three main theological purposes emerge from this analysis. First, the theologian may try only to systematize and clarify. Second, he may seek to create and strengthen concern for faith by showing its importance. Third, he may attempt instead so to formulate the faith as to remove all existing intellectual obstacles to its acceptance and to prevent new ones from arising. This third purpose will necessarily include the first because systematization and clarification are obviously involved in dealing with rational difficulties. Between the two remaining purposes of theology, no further reduction is possible. The task of showing the importance and value of faith and that of so formulating faith as to overcome all honest obstacles to its accept-

ance are complementary, and both are indispensable to the church at the present time.

Of these two the former is more extensively undertaken today than is the latter. Many theologians continue to pursue the work of systematization and clarification alone and sometimes to insist that this is the only legitimate form of theology. But few speak directly to the condition of the many sensitive persons, who, though deeply concerned with the faith and strongly inclined by experience within the church to its acceptance, are unable honestly to accept the beliefs which it seems to presuppose.

Theology directed to this latter purpose is the subject of this paper. It is not an effort to formulate such a theology but a methodological study propaedeutic to such an undertaking. As such, it seeks to indicate the proper subject matter, data, starting point, and method of this type of theology.

III

Even when such a purpose as this is agreed upon, much confusion remains as to the procedure which the theologian should adopt. One reason for this confusion is disagreement as to the proper subject matter of theology. Does it deal primarily with man as a spiritual being, with man's situation and redemption, with the working of spiritual forces in history, with particular persons and events of history, or with God himself? An adequate theology certainly must deal with all these topics, but if any one has prior claim to be the subject of theology, surely it is God. The etymology of the word suggests as much, and, although it is foolish to make an issue over word usages, this does imply that God should not be ignored by theology, treated in a

footnote or appendix, or merely taken for granted. Furthermore, it is with regard to the being and nature of God that there arise many of the most serious doubts with which the type of theology here considered is concerned. And, finally, if a procedure can be found which is adequate to this aspect of theology, it is highly probable that it will be helpful with regard to the others. Therefore, with no intention of limiting the subject matter of theology to God, it may reasonably be urged that, in the effort to locate data and starting point, their usefulness for the development of an adequate doctrine of God is a major criterion.

Where then can the theologian find data for a doctrine of God such that it will overcome all rational obstacles to belief? Clearly he cannot merely point to authoritative pronouncements in Bible and creed, for it is precisely in connection with such claims to authority that much serious doubt arises. Either such claims must themselves be substantiated in terms of less doubtful criteria or else more primitive data must be found.

Christian theologians may seek these more primitive data in the great redemptive events of Jesus' life, death, and resurrection, but they cannot ultimately be found there except as the events are understood to involve their own interpretations. The historical facts, even if they could be reliably extracted, could not provide adequate data for theology. In themselves, that is, as given to the historian who is not himself Christian, they say nothing of God's existence or nature, and nothing can be rationally deduced from them. Only as they are apprehended in an act of faith do they become a source of knowledge about God.

Ultimately, then, data for theology must be sought in experience, and when

knowledge of God is sought, experience of God must provide the data. Most Christians would agree that they experience God in and through the historical events discussed above, but at the moment this is not the issue. The Christian theologian looks to the Christian's experience of God to provide him with data for his statement of Christian knowledge of God.

Even when this is acknowledged, there remain three possible conceptions of the proper data for Christian theology. First, the experiences as such, that is, uninterpreted, may be regarded as the only reliable data. These are studied from many points of view. The psychologist, the sociologist, the historian, and the philosopher, all employ them. If theology wishes to achieve comparable reliability and win equal acceptance, it seems that it should employ the same data and a similar methodology. An important theological movement stemming from certain aspects of Schleiermacher's thought has attempted to limit itself to the data of religious experience. In some cases it has tended self-consciously to reduce theology to a psychology of religion, a sociology of religion, or a history of religion. In other cases, however, it has tried strenuously to maintain its distinctive function.

Henry Nelson Wieman makes perhaps the most consistent effort to treat of what is here regarded as the decisive test of theological method, that is, God, without surreptitiously intruding any data beyond religious experience *per se*. God is given in such experiences; he is not an inference from them or an interpretation of them. As the source of human good he is a specifiable structure of events in human experience or is identified with those events which exemplify this structure.

Wieman's thought is mentioned here not for systematic analysis and criticism

but to illustrate the inescapable limits by which a theology is bound in its description of God when it limits itself to description of uninterpreted religious experience. If God is considered at all, it must necessarily be as an aspect, quality, element, or characteristic of that experience. Whatever the precision with which the human experience of God may be described, most Christians have always felt that God's own being is something quite transcendent to this, and much Christian belief and practice presupposes this conception of God. To many, Wieman's analysis is a corroboration rather of their doubts than of their faith.

Second, some verbally formulated interpretation of Christian experience halloved by tradition and age-long reverence may be taken as the data for Christian theology. This approach can be distinguished from those considered briefly above only in so far as the authorities are here selected as authoritative in their capacity as interpretations of Christian experience rather than as divinely inspired writings or the accepted formulation of what is believed in a community. The Bible or some portion thereof, taken alone or in conjunction with some further interpretation, here again provides data for theology. This overcomes the difficulty in the previous method, for the Bible and its interpretations certainly speak freely of the Christian God. But a host of new difficulties arise. Even if attention is limited to the New Testament, innumerable different points of view are represented. A single writer may embrace a plurality of tendencies. Many ideas are present which seem altogether incompatible with our scientific knowledge of the world. And much of the New Testament seems to be written under a serious misapprehension that history was almost at an end.

If these difficulties are escaped by allegorical interpretation, they can have no check. Allegorizers will disagree limitlessly, and there appears to be no criterion for evaluation of their contradictory interpretations. Furthermore, there is no limit to what may be allegorized, so that theology is left without any stable data whatever.

The data of theology must involve some interpretation of the Christian's experience of God going beyond its analysis and objective description, but the letter of Scripture and creed cannot be employed. What alternative remains? The answer may be afforded by a closer analysis of both the claim of scripture to authority and the difficulty involved in acknowledging this claim.

Analysis of the content of the New Testament suggests that three elements have special claim to authority. First, the New Testament contains the only record of those events which Christians regard as decisive for all human history and for each individual life. Second, it contains the record of the teachings of one who Christians believe had a unique relation with God. Third, it recounts or reflects the response to these events and teachings of men whose spiritual depth and sensitivity has rarely been equaled and never surpassed.

As has been noted above, uninterpreted events cannot be the data for theology, because they are subject to innumerable interpretations. Jesus' teaching, however, as it reflects his knowledge of God, and the writings of early Christians, as they reflect their experience of God in the events of Jesus' life, teaching, and death, do provide data fully adequate to the theologian's task. Since Christian experience of God is expected to be the source of Christian knowledge of God, ex-

periences subsequent to the first century must also be considered.

However, the difficulty involved in employing scripture as data has already been noted. The historical narrative, Jesus' teaching, and the account of Christian experience are stated in the context of a first-century world view or, perhaps more accurately, of a variety of first-century world views. These provide not only the language but also many of the ideas, beliefs, and expectations which color the account. Sometimes these seem to be harmonious with the events and the experiences, sometimes in tension with them. The influence of a set of relativizing factors sharply different from those which determine our own thought renders its literal and unqualified acceptance impossible.

The theological data provided in the New Testament are therefore primarily in the accounts of subjective apprehension of God by Jesus and, by others, in the events surrounding his ministry and death. But these accounts must be purified of relativizing factors before they can constitute binding data. *The ideal data for Christian theology are interpretive expressions of Christian experience which are free of determination by cultural, social, and peculiarly personal factors.*

The presuppositions here are, first, that, since no two experiences can in themselves be contradictory, their interpretations cannot be contradictory in so far as they are conditioned by the experiences rather than by relativizing factors and, second, that experiences of God are sufficiently explicit in their self-interpretations to provide adequate data for theology. To explain and defend these presuppositions, the concept of interpretation used here needs clarification. Interpretation may refer to a meaning applied to an experience because of expectation

or training. Such interpretation is likely to be determined largely by relativizing factors. It may also, however, refer to a meaning which is an integral part of the experience, a meaning which may conflict with expectation and contradict training. The assumption here made is that man's interpretation of certain experiences as being "of God," and the characterization of God resulting therefrom, are of this sort, that is, are determined predominantly by the experience rather than by relativizing factors.

If this assumption is to be supported, further analysis of the roles of data and interpretation in experience is necessary. Every effort has been made in this paper to maintain a relative neutrality among philosophies in order that decisions as to theological method may be determined as little as possible by prior philosophic commitment. At this point, however, the impossibility of a neutral analysis becomes apparent. Sensationalistic philosophies insist that sensory images are the given facts of experience and that the idea that the experience is "of God" is extraneously added. Others hold that the sensory images are rather a derivative aspect of the experience and that the experience of the datum precedes it—in this case, that the experience is "of God" is given in the experience.

In either case, however, the argument for theology holds. In the former it must at least be admitted that the interpretation of certain experiences as being of certain objects conceived as more than and distinct from the sensory experiences of them is a natural and inevitable one. People will persist in feeling that certain experiences are of God with considerable independence of their training and expectation, just as they persist in interpreting other patterns of sensory experience as being "of other persons" con-

ceived as themselves independent subjects of experience. In the latter case it must still be recognized that in the communication of the experience to others the sensory images are necessarily the primary data for discourse and that comparison of several experiences or any attempt to test the validity of claims based on experiences must be based largely upon these. It is either this inevitable interpretation of sensory religious experience, or this prior awareness of God expressed in sensory and emotional experience, which constitutes what is here referred to as interpretation determined by the experience and is regarded as the only possible data for a theology which seeks adequacy to its subject and relevance to all those whose acceptance of Christian faith is hindered by doubt.

Such data are ideal rather than actual in the sense that they are never given in purity. The actual data are given verbal statements which are conditioned both by Christian experience in its distinctiveness and by the many relativizing (as well as universalizing) factors indicated above. Whether the ideal data are ever completely abstracted cannot be known. Furthermore, there can be no merely neutral vocabulary in which to express data abstracted from the old. The new expression, like the old, will be conditioned by relativizing factors independent of the experience.

This means that no final statement of Christian theology is possible in fact, even though Christian experience rests upon a once-for-all event and eternal truth. But theological statements are not for that reason merely relative. Where the criterion here stated is accepted, a basis is provided for discussion, which through the use of accepted scholarly techniques could progressively approach the ideal data.

IV

If the foregoing analysis is accepted, the question of the data for Christian theology is now answered. The theologian accepts as given all primitive interpretations of Christian experience of God. Indeed it may seriously be questioned whether, in his effort to achieve the widest relevance, he should not accept as data such interpretations of non-Christian experience as well. But, though all may alike be given, the Christian theologian cannot choose his starting point indiscriminately.

If the theologian were guided by a dominant scientific or philosophic concern, he might well seek for the common elements in such primitive interpretations of religious experience or at least of all that is Christian. The individual differences of the experiences would be of secondary concern. The theologian, however, shares the belief of those whose beliefs he studies, that an objective reality has become manifest with varying degrees of clarity in these experiences. The more complex are not to be explained, therefore, in terms of the simpler, but the simpler in terms of the more complex. The greater the penetration, the profundity, and the clarity of the experience, the more it appears to force its self-interpretation upon the subject even against his will; and the more indifferent it appears to prior training and expectation, the more credence and authority the theologian will attach to it. The starting point for the Christian theologian, then, is not the primitive interpretation of Christian experience generally but that of the profoundest and the clearest Christian experience.

A second criterion for selection of starting point is the distinctively Christian character of the experience. Within

the Christian community there have been those who have approached God relatively directly and have apprehended him in a fashion not sharply different from that in which adherents of other mystical religions have apprehended him. Again, the primitive interpretation of their experiences must be accounted for in a Christian theology. But the Christian theologian will attempt to illuminate them from the perspective of the more distinctively Christian experience.

Determination of this distinctiveness involves the difficulty that, if it is not merely to reflect a prior theological decision, it must be stated with utmost generality. The reference to Christ appears to come closest to meeting the requirements. The greater the role of Christ in an experience, the clearer and more certain, at least, is its distinctively Christian character.

Finally, the theologian who seeks a generality of relevance exceeding that of a particular community within Christendom will be well advised to choose experiences which antedate and are uncolored by the differences which now rend the church in pieces. To the Protestant theologian, Luther offers an outstanding example of what is sought—a profound, clear, distinctively Christian experience, objectively determined as to its self-interpretation to an unusual degree. Likewise, the vision of Bernadette is likely to commend itself highly to the Catholic theologian. But use of either of these as starting point necessarily limits the relevance of the statement. Both surely must ultimately be recognized as data to be accounted for, but the preferable starting point would be found elsewhere.

All the criteria are almost ideally satisfied in the New Testament record. Jesus' own experience and its interpretation

have a recognized relevance to all Christians, and those of Paul and of the author of the fourth Gospel are scarcely less universal. However extensive the data recognized by the Christian theologian may be, his starting point almost necessarily is the New Testament.

V

The data for Christian theology, then, can be neither Christian experience as such nor any particular interpretive formulation thereof. Their discovery and statement are the tasks of biblical exegesis supplemented by a study of the lives and thought of great Christians through the ages. This is an infinite task, so the systematic formulation of the data cannot await their perfect statement. For this formulation the teachings of Jesus, Paul, and the fourth Gospel, in so far as they are determined by their experience of God, provide the starting point. In proceeding from this starting point, how is the formulation of theology to be related to relativizing and absolutizing factors?

The answer to the first part of this question is that, ideally, Christian faith should be formulated in independence of all relativizing factors. The inherent claim of that faith to universality of relevance is necessarily vitiated when its statement is determined by factors relative to time, place, and personality. Yet, in the light of the modern emphasis upon the influence of such elements in all thought, the impossibility of perfect independence from them must be acknowledged. Certainly theology must seek freedom from determination by the personal preferences, expectations, and prejudices of the theologian. Yet no theologian can free his work from such determination, and in every group of theologians some such factors will be common and hence

unrecognized. Certainly theology must seek freedom from determination by those attitudes, beliefs, and aspirations which characterize the sociocultural environment of the theologian. But complete self-consciousness in regard to these also is impossible. Therefore, just as the ideal data for theology can never be perfectly attained, so also complete freedom from relativizing factors can never be achieved in the systematic statement of the faith. In this case, as in that, the ideal provides a goal to be progressively approached through the honest application of the critical techniques of scholarship.

The second part of this question poses a very different problem. The theologian may envision it as that of the relation of theological truth to truth in general, of theology to philosophy, or of revelation to reason. In their reaction against the tendency of certain earlier periods to render theology dependent upon current world views, some theologians have tended to assert the absolute independence of theology from every criterion except its subject and datum. But, if the theologian is to do more than point in silence, he cannot free himself from the universal demands upon human thought. If his affirmations are to have meaning as well as feeling, they cannot be mutually contradictory, for self-contradiction is tantamount to meaninglessness. Furthermore, if the self-consistent statements of a theologian are to claim credence also, they cannot be such as are contradicted by known facts in other areas of human experience. The demand of consistency here as everywhere extends to all fact. Finally, since it is precisely the apparent incompatibility of faith with knowledge and other experience which most commonly gives rise to honest doubt, the avoidance of such contradiction is of paramount importance.

The avoidance of contradiction with known fact is not a simple matter to be dealt with by common sense. The theologian cannot avoid contradiction of many intelligent interpretations of such facts. Therefore he must point to, or himself develop, some consistent interpretation of all knowledge which does not contradict his theological statement. The statement itself, while certainly not derived from any such interpretation, must be susceptible of analysis as to precise meaning in terms of such a system if both its meaningfulness and its consistency with all facts are to be displayed. Since the theologian as theologian is not an original philosopher, he must look to philosophy to provide him a vehicle for the statement of his truth and to guide him in his effort to obey the demand of consistency.

In any given philosophical system relativizing and absolutizing factors are both involved. No matter how critical and self-conscious the philosopher becomes, some culturally conditioned elements remain unquestioned. Furthermore, even the absolutizing factors are not absolute. The demand of self-consistency tends to overcome differences of time, place, and personality, yet the systems of logic and philosophic method which seek to embody it vary among themselves. The demand of consistency with all facts tends to rule out innumerable erroneous interpretations, but a plurality of interpretations always seem to remain as live options. The history of philosophy reveals no clear-cut progress toward univocal resolution of these divergences, but rather the periodic recurrence of certain patterns of philosophical thought. Although the body of scientific fact has vastly increased, the differences among philosophical positions today bear marked resemblances to those among

Aristotle, Plato, and Democritus in ancient Greece.

The theologian seeking assistance from philosophy is confronted with a bewildering problem. He must either abandon his effort to render theology consistent with all fact or enter the field of philosophy to make a decision which philosophers themselves have not been able to make. This is an extremely difficult and dangerous act, and no infallible guide to such a decision can be supplied; yet to abandon his interest in philosophy is to leave his statement needlessly inconsistent. Some additional consideration of the philosophical situation may assist in dealing with this dilemma.

Three formally exhaustive interpretations of this situation are possible. It may be that no philosophy is adequately inclusive in its consistency, that one and only one of the competing systems satisfies this criterion, or that a plurality of systems are consistent and adequate to all facts. If the first is true, then the theologian's attempt to achieve consistency with all fact must be abandoned as hopeless. If the second is true, it becomes of crucial importance to determine which philosophical system embodies this ultimate expression of truth. If the third is true, it is necessary only to select among adequate systems on the grounds of their suitability for the expression of theological truth.

Which of these interpretations is true is not a question which can be answered with assurance. Yet some evidence for the third, or at least for the propriety of theologians employing it as a working hypothesis, may be noted. Several major philosophical systems seem to have maintained themselves under sustained critical analysis through thousands of years with only incidental modification of their fundamental structure and meth-

od. Criticisms can be directed from any one of these against the others, but these criticisms can be answered from within the framework of the system criticized. The denial of adequacy to any usually rests on this fact of endless disagreement, but specific inadequacies must be shown in every system if that alternative is to be convincingly affirmed. Such an undertaking would seem altogether too presumptuous a venture for a theologian. The attempt to prove one system uniquely adequate initiates a search for universal criteria which so far has proved fruitless. For a theologian to undertake this task is for him to abandon theology for philosophy. Acceptance of the view that a plurality of adequate systems exists appears to be a more honest and humble recognition of the situation as it is. Even if it were not ultimately true, it would seem to recommend itself to the theologian as the most practical solution in the present era.

The theologian, then, must select some system of philosophy which appears to him capable of interpreting all the facts of human experience and knowledge. His selection will be on the grounds of its suitability for the expression and systematization of the peculiar data of Christian experience. In employing this system he will seek to divorce from all the relativizing factors involved that portion the value of which he recognizes as a technical solution to the problem of formulating a consistent interpretation of all facts. Here again he has an infinite goal, to be reached only approximately and progressively through critical scholarly processes.

Some guidance, however, subject to adaptation to each variant system, is possible. In general, he will separate such elements as the logic, methodology, metaphysics or cosmology, and episte-

mology from such other elements as specific scientific theories, specific preferences and evaluations, specific interpretations of history, and, above all, specific assertions of religious belief. In many philosophies complete separation is not possible even ideally. For example, metaphysical or epistemological systems may presuppose specific scientific theories. But in the writings of every philosopher much is to be found determined not by the systematic development of his criterion of consistency but rather by his social conditioning and personal training and interests. The theologian must never allow himself to be bound or even guided by this side of a philosopher's thought, however profound and penetrating may be his insights, unless the philosopher is also a man of profound Christian experience.

The chief elements in the theological method recommended by this analysis may be summarized as follows: The theologian's subject is coextensive with the subject of Christian belief. Within this area a place of great importance must be assigned to God, so a method incapable of adequately treating him must be discarded. The specific data for Christian theology must be found in Christian experience, but uninterpreted experience is susceptible of variant interpretations, and its analysis and description cannot achieve an adequate doctrine of God. On the other hand, such interpretations of Christian experience as are found in the Bible are conditioned by relativizing factors which render their literal acceptance impossible for the contemporary mind. The data for Christian theology must be primitive interpretations of Christian experience unconditioned by relativizing factors—an abstract ideal. If these data are to be systematized consistently with one another and with all other human

knowledge, they must be stated in relation to, and in terms of, an adequate and consistent interpretation of all facts, that is, an adequate philosophy. All philosophies, however, like all expression of religious experience are conditioned by relativizing factors, and the isolation of the absolutizing factors is again an abstract ideal.

With such a view as this of the theological enterprise, the theologian can escape, on the one hand, from all danger of dogmatism. He will be constantly aware of the inadequacy and imperfection of every theological statement, despite the absoluteness of the truth with which he deals. On the other hand, abandonment

of the dogmatic pretense to absoluteness need not mean the abandonment of criteria for evaluation of alternative statements or the transformation of theology into the expression of personal opinion and preference.

Finally, in principle, the method here outlined would overcome all rational obstacles to faith. Once a man is inclined by his religious experience to acceptance of the Christian faith, understanding of a statement which so displayed that faith as to demonstrate its compatibility with all knowledge eliminates any difficulty he may feel in their apparent inconsistency. No more important service can be rendered by theology today.